Environmental Impacts are Personal, Local and Global

The use of fuels, improper disposal of agricultural and human waste, use of inorganic materials and the by-products of agriculture, industrial and digital production and distribution alter the sustainable balance of nature and her bounty—clean air and water, green earth, blue skies, ambient temperatures, natural forests, wetlands and other ecospheres—harming both the environment and the people who inhabit it.

Adverse environmental impacts operate at three levels: individual or personal, local or social, and global.

Many impacts affect individuals. For instance, workers in a slate-producing industry can get silicosis; workers in chemical factories are exposed to health hazards in the form of leaks; and women cooking with dung or wood are exposed to noxious fumes and black carbon. There are numerous production and consumption processes for both goods and services that expose millions of people to adverse impacts.

Most impacts are local, confined to an area that may be large or small but is localized. A thermal power plant spewing smoke sends out particulate material of small sizes (2.5 mm and 10 mm), which affects human health, and noxious gases such as nitrogen oxide, sulphur oxide and mercury. These pollutants spread over a certain area and settle down, or get blown to another area nearby. The burning of paddy stubble by farmers in Punjab in September–October every year to clear their fields to sow wheat spreads black carbon, particulate matter and other pollutants over a larger local area of India. Delhi bears the noxious consequences every year of such stubble burning.

Some environmental impacts are global. Coal-based power plants produce CO_2 while burning carbon in coal. Rotting of agro-waste or growing of paddy in water produces methane. CO_2 and methane are GHGs. Once produced, they remain in the atmosphere forever until sequestered or